

Multiple births

Carrying twins or more increases the risk of complications during birth, and you and your babies will be closely monitored.

Twin pregnancies occur naturally in around 1 in 53 women, but some factors increase the chance of you conceiving twins or more, including the use of some fertility treatments, becoming pregnant when you're older, already having children, and having a family history of twins.

Monitoring during pregnancy

Because multiple pregnancies are high risk, you'll receive extra monitoring; the type of delivery depends on the position of your twins and other complications. A concern is whether twins will be born prematurely with a small birth weight, which can mean spending time in a [neonatal intensive care unit](#).

Toward the end of pregnancy, you may have extra scans to monitor the babies' growth, since the ability of the placenta to provide oxygen can be reduced in a twin pregnancy. The volume of the fluid around each baby and their heart rates may be measured to check their well-being.

Possible complications

Twin-to-twin transfusion syndrome (TTTS) is a condition unique to identical twins who share a placenta (see [The lost twin](#)). It occurs if there is a direct link in the blood supply between the babies and can put the lives of both at risk. Babies with TTTS need specialized treatment that may involve reducing the fluid around one baby or using a laser to separate the circulations.

Rarely, twins can develop in the same sac, known as monoamniotic twins. This is an extremely high risk situation in which the umbilical cords can become tangled, affecting the oxygen supply. Monoamniotic twins are typically monitored in the hospital starting at 24 weeks and are usually delivered early by Cesarean section.

Maternal complications There is a higher risk of complications, such as [preeclampsia](#), possibly because of the additional strain on the kidneys; the liver condition [cholestasis](#), for reasons that are unclear; and thrombosis, because there is an additional strain on your circulation. These conditions may also mean that an early cesarean is recommended.

Going into labor

You're more likely to go into labor early and your babies may be lighter than average. With twins, you're likely to go into labor around 37 weeks; triplets around 34 weeks; quadruplets around 32 weeks. The average birthweight for twins is 5.5 lb (2.5 kg); triplets and quadruplets are almost always low-birthweight.

Labor and birth

Current recommendations are that an obstetrician should attend a twin birth. If you're planning to have a vaginal birth, the labor should be almost as quick as it is with one baby.

Continuous monitoring of both heartbeats is recommended during a multiple labor. This is usually done by putting one strap around your belly for each baby, but